

Title I Paraprofessional Assessment Study Guide

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Focus: Foundational Academic Skills & K-3 Instructional Scenarios

Welcome! This study guide is designed to help you prepare for the Title I Paraprofessional Assessment. To meet the "Highly Qualified" standard, paraeducators must demonstrate two things:

1. **Personal Proficiency:** A solid grasp of foundational reading, writing, and math skills.
2. **Instructional Capability:** The ability to effectively assist early childhood and lower-elementary students (Kindergarten through 3rd grade) in learning these skills.

Part 1: The Reading Module

1. Foundational Reading Skills

The test will ask you to read short passages and answer questions about them.

- **Reading Comprehension (Main Idea & Details):** You must be able to identify the primary point of a passage and locate specific details that support that point.
- **Vocabulary & Context Clues:** You may be asked to define a word (like *ambiguous* or *substantiate*) based on how it is used in a sentence. Look at the surrounding words for clues.
- **Fact vs. Opinion:** Remember that a *fact* can be proven true or false (e.g., "The MSDS sheets are in the office"), while an *opinion* expresses a belief, feeling, or judgment (e.g., "Cleaning a spill is the hardest job").
- **Author's Tone & Purpose:** Pay attention to *how* a passage is written. Is it instructional (giving directions), persuasive (trying to convince you), or narrative (telling a story)?

2. K-3 Reading Instructional Scenarios

- **Phonemic Awareness (Kindergarten):** This is the ability to hear and manipulate individual sounds (phonemes) in spoken words. If a student is segmenting the word "cat," they should say the sounds /k/ - /a/ - /t/, not the letter names (C-A-T).
- **Decoding Strategies (K-1st Grade):** When a young reader gets stuck on a word, do not just read it for them. Prompt them to use phonics ("What sound does the first letter make?") and context/visual cues ("Let's look at the picture for a clue").
- **Fluency Interventions (1st-2nd Grade):** Fluency is reading at a steady, conversational pace. A great tool for a paraeducator to use is **Choral Reading**, where you and the student read the same text aloud together at the same time.
- **Reading Comprehension Strategies (1st-3rd Grade):**
 - *Predicting:* Before starting a book, use the title and cover picture to ask, "What do you think this book will be about?"

- *Fix-up Strategies*: If a student forgets what they just read, have them stop, slowly reread the page, and verbally summarize what happened.
- **Text Features & Reference Tools (2nd-3rd Grade)**:
 - *Glossary*: A mini-dictionary at the back of a textbook (best place to find the definition of a specific word like "habitat").
 - *Thesaurus*: A tool used to find synonyms (words with similar meanings, like finding another word for "happy").
- **Figurative Language**: When a text says a puppy is "as fast as a rocket" (a simile), help the child understand that the author is comparing their speed to show *how* fast the puppy ran, not that the puppy is literally a rocket.

Part 2: The Writing Module

1. Foundational Writing Skills (Grammar & Mechanics)

- **Subject-Verb Agreement**: Singular subjects need singular verbs; plural subjects need plural verbs. (*Correct: "The class has decided to play a game."*)
- **Pronoun-Antecedent Agreement**: A pronoun must match the noun it replaces in number and gender. (*Correct: "Each of the girls brought her own lunch."*)
- **Sentence Structure (Fragments & Run-ons)**: A complete sentence needs a subject and a verb and must express a complete thought.
 - *Fragment*: "Waiting for the school bus in the pouring rain." (Missing a subject/verb—who is waiting?)
 - *Run-on/Comma Splice*: Avoid mashing two sentences together with just a comma. (*Incorrect: "I love reading books, it teaches me things." Correct: "I love reading books; it teaches me things."*)
- **Punctuation & Capitalization**:
 - *Apostrophes*: Used for possession (the *teachers'* lounge) and contractions (*They're* going to the park).
 - *Capitalization*: Capitalize proper nouns (names, specific places, months) but do not capitalize general seasons (fall, winter) or general locations (the library) unless part of a proper name.
- **Modifiers**: Ensure descriptive phrases are placed next to the noun they are describing.
 - *Dangling Modifier*: "Exhausted from the playground, the bell rang." (The bell wasn't exhausted; the student was).
- **Commonly Confused Words**: Know the difference between **Affect** (a verb meaning to influence) and **Effect** (a noun meaning the result).

2. K-3 Writing Instructional Scenarios

- **The Writing Process**:
 - *Pre-writing (Brainstorming)*: If a student is stuck staring at a blank page, ask guiding questions to help them make personal connections (e.g., "Do you have any pets at home?").

- *Drafting (Fluency)*: When young students are writing their first draft, encourage **inventive spelling**. Tell them to write the sounds they hear and move on. Stopping to look up every single word ruins their writing flow and train of thought.
- *Revising vs. Editing*: **Revising** is about the *content* (Does the story have a clear beginning, middle, and end? Do the ideas make sense?). **Editing** is about the *mechanics* (spelling, capitalization, punctuation).
- **Supporting English Learners (EL)**: For very young EL students who have great ideas but lack English vocabulary, allow them to draw pictures of their story first, and then help them label key items in English.
- **Providing Constructive Feedback**: Do not cover a student's paper in red ink. Focus on one or two specific types of errors that align with the current lesson objective (e.g., just focusing on fixing capital letters today).
- **Using Rubrics**: If a student asks, "Am I done?", use the teacher's rubric (checklist). Say, "Let's read through your paper together and compare it to the checklist to see if you missed anything."
- **Peer Review**: Young students need structure to give good feedback. Provide a simple checklist, like asking them to identify "one thing they liked and one question they have" about their partner's story.

Part 3: The Math Module

1. Foundational Math Skills

- **Order of Operations (PEMDAS)**: Parentheses, Exponents, Multiplication & Division (left to right), Addition & Subtraction (left to right).
 - *Example*: $8 + 4 \times 3 - 2 \rightarrow$ Multiply first ($4 \times 3 = 12$) $\rightarrow$ Add ($8 + 12 = 20$) $\rightarrow$ Subtract ($20 - 2 = 18$).
- **Fractions**: To add fractions with different denominators, find a common denominator. (*Example*: $\frac{1}{3} + \frac{2}{5} = \frac{5}{15} + \frac{6}{15} = \frac{11}{15}$).
- **Percentages & Discounts**: To find a 20% discount on \$300, multiply $300 \times 0.20 = 60$. Subtract the discount from the total ($\$300 - \$60 = \$240$).
- **Basic Algebra**: Isolate the variable (x). (*Example*: $3x - 5 = 16 \rightarrow$ Add 5 to both sides $\rightarrow 3x = 21 \rightarrow$ Divide by 3 $\rightarrow x = 7$).
- **Geometry**:
 - **Area**: The space inside a shape (Length x Width). *Example*: A rug that is 12ft by 9ft has an Area of 108 square feet.
 - **Perimeter**: The distance around the outside of a shape (Add all sides). *Example*: A fence around a 40x30 play area requires $(40+40+30+30) = 140$ feet of fencing.
- **Statistics (Mean/Average)**: Add all the numbers together, then divide by how many numbers there are.
- **Ratios/Proportions**: If a recipe needs 2 cups of flour for 3 batches, and you want to make 9 batches (which is 3 times as much), you need 3 times the flour ($2 \times 3 = 6$ cups).

2. K-3 Math Instructional Scenarios

- **Visual Models & Manipulatives:**
 - *Fractions:* Use physical fraction tiles or circles to help a 3rd grader visualize why $\frac{1}{2}$ is the same size as $\frac{2}{4}$.
 - *Addition Strategies:* Use a **Ten-Frame** to help 1st graders visually bridge to ten (e.g., for $8 + 5$, fill 8 spots, add 5 more to see it fills a 10-frame with 3 left over, making 13).
- **Word Problem Strategies:** When a student shuts down at a word problem, do not just give them the answer. Say, "Let's read it together and underline what it's asking us to find."
- **Checking for Understanding:** Asking "Does that make sense?" is ineffective because students usually just nod yes. Instead, ask the student to *talk you through their steps* as they solve the next problem on their own.
- **Error Analysis:** You must be able to figure out *why* a student got a wrong answer so you can fix the root of the problem.
 - *Subtraction* (e.g., $52 - 18 = 44$): The student forgot how to regroup (borrow). They just subtracted the smaller number from the larger number in the ones place ($8 - 2 = 6$, or they just guessed 4) instead of borrowing from the tens.
 - *Multiplication* (e.g., $14 \times 3 = 312$): The student lacks an understanding of place value. They multiplied $3 \times 4 = 12$ and $3 \times 1 = 3$ and just wrote the numbers side-by-side instead of carrying the ten.
- **Math Anxiety:** If a student is overwhelmed by a full worksheet, use "chunking." Cover up the rest of the page with a blank paper and just focus on the very first step of problem number one together.

General Test-Taking Tips

- **Focus on the Process, Not Just the Answer:** For the scenario questions, the test wants to see if you can guide a student to discover the answer themselves. Choose options that involve *prompting, questioning, and the use of visual tools* rather than just giving the student the answer.
- **Read Carefully:** Watch out for negative phrasing like "Which of the following is NOT..." or "Identify the sentence with an error."
- **Pace Yourself:** You have as much time as you need. Use scratch paper for the math problems and double-check your arithmetic!

Expanded Reading Module

Title I Paraprofessional Assessment: Expanded Reading Module

Focus: Foundational Reading Comprehension & K-3 Literacy Instruction

Welcome to the expanded Reading Module. As a Title I paraprofessional working in early elementary education (Grades K-3), you are at the forefront of helping children transition from "learning to read" to "reading to learn."

To be effective, you must demonstrate two core competencies. First, you need a strong personal command of reading comprehension and analysis (Personal Proficiency). Second, you must understand the developmental stages of early literacy and know how to guide young readers through them without simply giving them the answers (Instructional Capability).

Part 1: Foundational Reading Skills (Personal Proficiency)

The assessment will evaluate your ability to read adult-level passages (such as school policies, memos, or informative articles) and accurately interpret them.

1. Main Idea and Supporting Details

The **main idea** is the central point the author makes. It is what the passage is mostly about.

Supporting details are the specific facts, examples, or reasons that back up the main idea.

- **Tip for the Test:** The main idea is frequently stated in the first sentence (topic sentence) or the last sentence (concluding sentence) of a paragraph. Ask yourself, "If I had to summarize this paragraph in one sentence, what would I say?"
- **Example:** If a paragraph describes the life cycle of a butterfly, the diet of a caterpillar, and the migration patterns of monarchs, the main idea is "The characteristics and life cycle of butterflies," while the specific diet is just a supporting detail.

2. Making Inferences (Reading Between the Lines)

An inference is an educated guess based on evidence from the text combined with your own background knowledge. The author won't tell you the answer directly; you have to deduce it.

- **Text:** "Sam sighed, closed his heavy textbook, rubbed his eyes, and looked at the clock. It was 2:00 AM."
- **Inference:** Sam is tired and has been studying for a long time. The text never says "Sam is tired," but the clues (rubbing eyes, late hour, heavy textbook) lead you to that conclusion.

3. Vocabulary and Context Clues

You will encounter words you might not know, but the surrounding text will provide clues to their meaning.

- **Definition/Explanation Clues:** Sometimes the author defines the word right after using it. *"The instructions were **ambiguous**, or unclear, leading to confusion."*
- **Synonym Clues:** Words with similar meanings are used nearby. *"The girl was **timid**; she was so shy she hid behind her mother."*
- **Antonym Clues:** Words with opposite meanings are used to show contrast. *"Unlike her loud, outgoing sister, Maria was very **introverted**."*

4. Fact vs. Opinion

- **Fact:** A statement that can be proven true or false through objective evidence. (e.g., *"The library opens at 8:00 AM."*)
- **Opinion:** A statement that expresses a belief, feeling, or judgment. Watch for "value words" like *best, worst, beautiful, should, hardest, or unfair*. (e.g., *"The library is the best place in the school."*)

5. Author's Purpose (PIE)

Why did the author write the passage? Think of the acronym **PIE**:

- **Persuade:** To convince the reader to do or believe something (e.g., an editorial about why the school needs a new playground).
- **Inform:** To give facts, directions, or instructional information (e.g., a science textbook, an MSDS chemical sheet, a recipe).
- **Entertain:** To tell a story for enjoyment (e.g., a fictional narrative about a dragon).

6. Text Structure

Pay attention to how a passage is organized:

- **Chronological / Sequence:** Arranged by time (first, next, then, finally).
- **Cause and Effect:** Shows how one event makes another event happen (because, therefore, as a result).
- **Problem and Solution:** Presents an issue and how it was fixed.
- **Compare and Contrast:** Shows how two things are alike and different (similarly, on the other hand).

Part 2: K-3 Reading Instructional Scenarios (Instructional Skills)

This section focuses on how to teach reading. In K-3, paraprofessionals work with students at highly varied skill levels.

1. Phonological vs. Phonemic Awareness (Pre-K to 1st Grade)

These terms are often confused, but they are crucial for early literacy. Both are **auditory** skills. You can do them completely in the dark—no letters involved!

- **Phonological Awareness:** The broad umbrella term for recognizing sounds in spoken language. This includes clapping out syllables (bas-ket-ball), recognizing rhyming words (cat/hat), and identifying the first sound in a word.
- **Phonemic Awareness:** A specific, more advanced sub-skill under that umbrella. It is the ability to hear, isolate, and manipulate the *individual* sounds (phonemes) in spoken words.
 - *Example Task:* If you ask a student to segment the spoken word "dog," they should say the sounds /d/ - /o/ - /g/. They should **not** say the letter names (D-O-G).

2. Phonics & Decoding (K-2nd Grade)

Phonics is the bridge between sounds (phonemes) and written letters (graphemes). When a student is reading a book and gets stuck on an unknown word:

- **Ineffective Approach:** Just reading the word to them or telling them to guess randomly based on the picture.
- **Effective Scaffolding:** Prompt them to decode (sound it out). "Let's point to the first letter. What sound does that make? Good, now what sound does the next letter make? Let's blend them together."
- **Blending vs. Segmenting:** *Blending* is squishing sounds together to read a word (c-a-t -> cat). *Segmenting* is pulling a word apart into sounds to spell it (cat -> c-a-t).

3. Sight Words / High-Frequency Words

These are words that appear constantly in early text (the, said, was, of). Many of them cannot be easily "sounded out" because they break standard phonics rules.

- **Paraeducator Role:** Assist with fluency through repetition. You might use flashcards, word walls, or a strategy called "heart words" (where the student sounds out the regular parts of the word but draws a heart above the tricky part they have to memorize by heart, like the "ai" in "said").

4. Reading Fluency (1st-3rd Grade)

Fluency is reading like you talk. A fluent reader doesn't sound like a robot. Fluency has three components:

1. **Accuracy:** Reading the words correctly.
2. **Rate:** Reading at an appropriate speed (not too slow, not racing).

3. **Prosody:** Reading with expression, changing tone for characters, and pausing appropriately at commas and periods.

Fluency Interventions:

- **Choral Reading:** The paraeducator and the student read the same text aloud together at the same time. This builds confidence.
- **Echo Reading:** The paraeducator reads a sentence with great expression. The student then "echoes" it back, mimicking the pacing and tone.

5. Reading Comprehension Strategies

Just because a child can read the words out loud doesn't mean they understand what they are reading.

- **Before Reading (Predicting):** Activate prior knowledge. Have the student look at the cover, title, and pictures. Ask, "What do you think this book will be about?"
- **During Reading (Visualizing):** Ask the student to paint a picture in their mind of what is happening.
- **After Reading (Summarizing/Fix-Up Strategies):** If a student finishes a page and says, "I don't remember what happened," give them a **Fix-Up Strategy**. Have them stop, slowly reread the page, and verbally summarize what happened after every paragraph using the 5 Ws (Who, What, Where, When, Why).

6. Reference Tools and Text Features (2nd-3rd Grade)

Helping students navigate non-fiction texts.

- **Table of Contents:** Found at the front; shows chapters and page numbers.
- **Glossary:** A mini-dictionary at the back of a textbook. (e.g., If a student doesn't know what "photosynthesis" means in their science book, prompt them to check the glossary).
- **Index:** Found at the back; an alphabetical list of specific topics and the pages where they are mentioned.
- **Thesaurus:** A tool used to find synonyms (words with similar meanings).

Practice Scenarios for the Assessment

1. A kindergarten student is looking at a picture book and stops at the word "bat." They look frustrated and ask you what it says. What is the most pedagogically sound response?

- *Correct Approach:* "Let's look at the first letter. What sound does 'b' make? Now let's stretch out the rest of the sounds and blend them together."

- *Why:* Giving them the word doesn't teach them how to read. Prompting them to use phonics skills builds independence.

2. You are doing a reading intervention with a second-grade student who reads very accurately, but reads in a slow, robotic, monotone voice. What is the best strategy to use?

- *Correct Approach:* Echo reading. You read a sentence with proper expression and pauses, and have the student repeat it back to you using the same voice.
- *Why:* The student has mastered *accuracy*, but lacks *prosody* (expression) and *rate*. Echo reading models what fluent reading sounds like.

3. A third-grade student is reading a chapter book. They finish a page, look up, and say, "I have no idea what I just read." What should the paraeducator do?

- *Correct Approach:* Tell the student to use a "fix-up strategy" by rereading the page slowly and stopping after each paragraph to verbally summarize what just happened.
- *Why:* Summarizing and chunking the text helps build active comprehension. Telling them to just keep reading will only increase their confusion.

4. While reading a story, a first-grade student points to a word and asks, "Why is the word *CRASH* written in all capital letters?" How should you explain this?

- *Correct Approach:* Explain that the author is using onomatopoeia (a sound word) and capitalizing it to show the reader how loud the sound was in the story.
- *Why:* This teaches the student about the author's purpose and how text features inform expression and comprehension.

Key Takeaway for the Exam: In K-3 reading scenarios, the right answer almost always involves **prompting the student to use a strategy** (sounding it out, looking for context clues, summarizing, making a prediction) rather than the adult doing the mental work for them.

Expanded Writing Module

Title I Paraprofessional Assessment: Expanded Writing Module

Focus: Foundational Grammar & K-3 Writing Instruction Strategies

Welcome to the expanded Writing Module. As a Title I paraprofessional, your role in writing instruction is twofold. First, you must demonstrate a strong personal command of standard English conventions. Second, and perhaps more importantly, you must know how to effectively guide early childhood and lower-elementary students (Kindergarten through 3rd grade) through the writing process without simply doing the work for them.

This module is broken into two parts: Personal Proficiency (Foundational Skills) and Instructional Capability (Pedagogical Scenarios).

Part 1: Foundational Writing Skills (Personal Proficiency)

The assessment will evaluate your grasp of basic grammar, mechanics, and syntax. You need to identify errors in sentences and choose the most effective way to communicate ideas.

1. Subject-Verb Agreement

The basic rule is that a singular subject takes a singular verb, and a plural subject takes a plural verb.

- **Singular:** The **dog** (subject) **runs** (verb) in the yard.
- **Plural:** The **dogs** (subject) **run** (verb) in the yard.

Common Pitfalls:

- **Phrases between the subject and verb:** The verb must agree with the true subject, not a noun tucked inside a descriptive phrase.
 - *Incorrect:* The box of crayons belong on the desk. (The verb "belong" is incorrectly agreeing with "crayons").
 - *Correct:* The **box** of crayons **belongs** on the desk.
- **Indefinite Pronouns:** Words like *everyone, everybody, each, anyone, someone* are usually singular.
 - *Correct:* **Every one** of the students **is** getting a sticker. (Not "are").
- **Collective Nouns:** Groups acting as a single unit take a singular verb.
 - *Correct:* The **class** **has** decided to play a game.
 - *Correct:* The **jury** **is** reaching a verdict.

2. Pronoun-Antecedent Agreement

A pronoun (he, she, it, they) must match the noun it replaces (the antecedent) in number and

gender.

- *Incorrect:* Each of the girls brought their own lunch. (Girls is plural, but "each" is singular, so "their" is incorrect).
- *Correct:* **Each** of the girls brought **her** own lunch.
- *Correct:* The **school** updated **its** policy on absences. (School is an "it", not a "they").

Note: In modern conversational English, the singular "they" is widely accepted, but standardized tests often still require strict traditional agreement unless the gender of a singular individual is unknown or non-binary.

3. Sentence Structure (Fragments, Run-ons, and Comma Splices)

A complete sentence requires a subject (who or what), a predicate/verb (action), and must express a complete thought.

- **Fragments:** Missing a core component or a complete thought.
 1. *Fragment:* Waiting for the school bus in the pouring rain. (Who is waiting?)
 2. *Correction:* **The children were** waiting for the school bus in the pouring rain.
 3. *Fragment:* Because the bell rang. (This is a dependent clause and needs an independent clause to finish the thought).
 4. *Correction:* Because the bell rang, **the students packed their bags.**
- **Run-ons:** Two independent clauses mashed together without punctuation.
 1. *Incorrect:* I love reading books it teaches me things.
- **Comma Splices:** Using *only* a comma to join two complete sentences.
 1. *Incorrect:* The weather was freezing, we decided to go outside anyway.
- **Fixing Run-ons/Comma Splices:**
 1. Use a period: I love reading books. It teaches me things.
 2. Use a semicolon: The weather was freezing; we decided to go outside anyway.
 3. Use a comma and a conjunction (FANBOYS: for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so): The weather was freezing, **but** we decided to go outside anyway.

4. Punctuation and Capitalization

Apostrophes: Used for two specific reasons:

1. **Contractions:** To show missing letters (e.g., *do not* -> *don't*, *they are* -> *they're*).
2. **Possession:** To show ownership.
 - Singular owner: Add **'s** (The **student's** backpack).
 - Plural owner ending in 's': Add an apostrophe after the 's' (The **teachers'** lounge).
 - *Watch out for "Its" vs. "It's":* "It's" means *it is* or *it has*. "Its" implies ownership (The dog lost **its** ball).

Capitalization Rules:

- **Do Capitalize:** Proper nouns (names of specific people, places, things), days of the week, months, holidays, titles preceding names (President Washington).
- **Do NOT Capitalize:** General seasons (fall, winter), directions (driving north), or general locations unless part of a specific name (e.g., "I went to the library" vs. "I went to the Canon City Public Library").

5. Misplaced and Dangling Modifiers

A modifier is a word or phrase that describes something. It must be placed right next to the noun it is describing. If it's too far away (misplaced) or the noun is missing entirely (dangling), the sentence becomes confusing or unintentionally funny.

- *Dangling:* Barking loudly, the boy chased the dog down the street. (Was the boy barking?)
- *Correction:* Barking loudly, the **dog** chased the ball down the street.
- *Dangling:* Exhausted from the playground, the bell rang. (The bell wasn't exhausted).
- *Correction:* Exhausted from the playground, **the student** fell asleep during story time.

6. Commonly Confused Words

- **Affect vs. Effect:**
 - *Affect* is usually a **verb** (action) meaning to influence. ("The rain will *affect* our plans.")
 - *Effect* is usually a **noun** (thing) meaning the result. ("The new policy had a positive *effect*.")
 - *Hint:* **Affect = Action.**
- **Their, There, They're:**
 - *Their:* Possession (That is *their* book).
 - *There:* Location (The book is over *there*).
 - *They're:* Contraction for "they are" (*They're* reading the book).
- **To, Too, Two:**
 - *To:* Direction or infinitive verb (Going *to* the store *to* buy milk).
 - *Too:* Also, or excessively (I ate *too* much candy, and she did *too*).
 - *Two:* The number (I have *two* dogs).

Part 2: K-3 Writing Instructional Scenarios (Pedagogical Skills)

In the lower elementary grades, paraprofessionals are vital in helping students transition from oral language to written expression. The focus is on the *process* of writing and developing

fluency, rather than demanding perfect mechanics on the first try.

1. Fine Motor Skills and "Writing Readiness" (Pre-K to Kindergarten)

Before a child can write a paragraph, they must develop the physical ability to write.

- **Role of the Paraeducator:** Encourage activities that build small muscle strength in the hands and fingers.
- **Strategies:**
 - Pinching playdough or clay.
 - Using tweezers to pick up small objects.
 - Practicing proper pencil grip (tripod grasp).
 - "Writing" in sensory bins (sand, shaving cream, or salt trays) before moving to paper.

2. The Writing Process: A Step-by-Step Guide

The writing process is a cycle: Planning, Drafting, Revising, Editing, and Publishing.

A. Pre-writing / Planning (Brainstorming)

This is often the hardest part for young students. They may stare at a blank page and say, "I don't know what to write."

- **Ineffective Approach:** Telling the student what to write (e.g., "Just write about a dog, that's easy.") or making them look up definitions.
- **Effective Approach (Scaffolding):** Help them make personal connections and organize their thoughts.
 - **Ask Guiding Questions:** "Tell me about..." "What do you like to do on the weekend?" "Do you have any pets at home?"
 - **Use Graphic Organizers:** Help them fill out a simple "Web" or "Think Sheet" (e.g., a circle in the middle with the topic, and spokes branching out with ideas).
 - **Drawing as Pre-writing:** For K-1 students, drawing a detailed picture *is* pre-writing. The picture holds their story before they have the vocabulary to write it.

B. Drafting (Getting Ideas Down)

The goal of the first draft is **fluency**—getting ideas out of the brain and onto the paper without stopping.

- **The Concept of "Inventive Spelling":** Young students (K-1) should be encouraged to write the sounds they hear (e.g., writing "kat" for cat or "fone" for phone).
- **Why?** If a student stops to ask "how do you spell..." every single word, they lose their train of thought, and their writing becomes disjointed and frustrating.

- **Paraeducator Response:** If a student asks how to spell a word during a draft, prompt them: "What sounds do you hear? Write those down and circle it so we can fix it later. Keep writing!" Do not spell every word for them.

C. Revising vs. Editing (They are NOT the same thing!)

It is critical to know the difference on the assessment.

- **Revising (Content & Organization):** This is about the "meat" of the story.
 - *Focus:* Does it make sense? Is there a clear beginning, middle, and end? Are there good details? Does the topic sentence fit?
 - *Paraeducator Role:* Ask, "I noticed you added a puppy to the story, but where did he come from? What do you think you could add to explain that?"
- **Editing (Mechanics):** This is the final polish.
 - *Focus:* Capital letters, punctuation, spelling (fixing those inventive spelling words).
 - *Paraeducator Role:* When pointing out errors on a rough draft, **do not cover the paper in red ink.** This is demoralizing. Instead, focus on one or two specific types of errors that align with the teacher's current lesson (e.g., "Today, let's just hunt for missing capital letters at the beginning of our sentences.")

D. Publishing and Sharing

Creating an engaged community of writers means giving their writing an audience.

- **Peer Review:** K-3 students need high structure to do this well. If a second grader just writes "It is good" on a partner's paper, guide them to use a specific framework (e.g., "Tell your partner one specific thing you liked about their character, and ask one question about what happens next.")
- **Using Rubrics:** If a third-grader asks, "Am I done?" don't just say yes or no. Use the teacher's rubric (checklist). Say, "Let's read your paper together and compare it to the checklist to see if you hit all the marks."

3. Supporting Specific Student Populations

- **English Learners (EL):** An EL kindergarten student may have a brilliant story in their head but lack the English vocabulary to draft it.
 - *Scaffolding Strategy:* Allow them to draw the entire story first in detailed pictures. Then, sit with them and help them label key items in the picture using English words. You can also allow them to dictate the story to you while you write (transcribing) as a bridge to independent writing.
- **Students with Learning Disabilities:** For students who struggle with working memory or organization, break the writing task down into tiny, manageable "chunks." If writing a whole paragraph is overwhelming, fold the paper or use a sticky note to cover everything

except the very first sentence they need to write.

Practice Scenarios for the Assessment

1. A second-grade student is writing an informative paragraph about frogs. Their current first sentence is: "Frogs are a thing." How should the paraeducator assist?

- *Correct Approach:* Ask guiding questions to help them make it more specific. "What *kind* of thing is a frog? An animal? An amphibian? What is one interesting fact you learned about them that we can put in the first sentence?"

2. A first-grade student is writing a story but stops after every word to ask you how to spell it. How should the paraeducator respond to promote writing fluency?

- *Correct Approach:* Tell them to write the sounds they hear (inventive spelling) and circle words they aren't sure about to fix later during the editing phase.

3. You are helping a third-grade student with the *Revising* stage of their short story. Which of the following should you focus on?

- *Correct Approach:* Ask the student whether their story has a clear beginning, middle, and end, and whether the events make sense. (Checking for periods and capitals is *editing*).

4. A kindergarten student stops at a word they want to write, looks frustrated, and says, "I can't do it." What is a helpful prompt?

- *Correct Approach:* "What are the sounds you hear in that word? Can you draw a picture of it first?" (Avoid just telling them to copy a word from the board or writing it for them).

Key Takeaway for the Exam: When answering instructional scenario questions, always look for the option that involves **prompting, questioning, scaffolding (like drawing or using graphic organizers), and preserving the student's train of thought**. Avoid answers that have the adult doing the work for the student or demanding immediate perfection.

Expanded Math Module

Title I Paraprofessional Assessment: Expanded Math Module

Focus: Foundational Mathematics & K-3 Math Instruction Strategies

Welcome to the expanded Math Module. As a Title I paraprofessional working with early childhood and lower-elementary students (Kindergarten through 3rd grade), you play a crucial role in building foundational numeracy.

To be effective, you must demonstrate two core competencies. First, you need a strong personal command of foundational mathematics, ranging from basic arithmetic to early algebra and geometry (Personal Proficiency). Second, you must understand how young children conceptualize math and know how to guide them through problem-solving using visual tools and scaffolding (Instructional Capability).

Part 1: Foundational Math Skills (Personal Proficiency)

The assessment will evaluate your ability to solve standard math problems accurately. Even though you are working with K-3 students, Title I requires paraeducators to demonstrate proficiency up to an 8th-grade math level.

1. Order of Operations (PEMDAS)

When a math problem has multiple operations (addition, multiplication, etc.), you must solve them in a specific order. Remember the acronym **PEMDAS** (Please Excuse My Dear Aunt Sally):

1. **P**arentheses
 2. **E**xponents
 3. **M**ultiplication and **D**ivision (from left to right)
 4. **A**ddition and **S**ubtraction (from left to right)
- *Example:* $8 + 4 \times 3 - 2$
 - *Step 1 (Multiply):* $4 \times 3 = 12$
 - *Step 2 (Rewrite):* $8 + 12 - 2$
 - *Step 3 (Add/Subtract left to right):* $20 - 2 = 18$

2. Fractions

- **Adding and Subtracting:** You must have a common denominator (the bottom number) before you can add or subtract the numerators (the top numbers).
 - *Example:* $\frac{1}{3} + \frac{2}{5}$
 - *Step 1 (Find common denominator):* The lowest common multiple of 3 and 5 is 15.

- Step 2 (Convert): $\frac{1}{3} = \frac{5}{15}$ and $\frac{2}{5} = \frac{6}{15}$
- Step 3 (Add): $\frac{5}{15} + \frac{6}{15} = \frac{11}{15}$

- **Simplifying:** Always reduce fractions to their lowest terms (e.g., $\frac{4}{8}$ simplifies to $\frac{1}{2}$).

3. Percentages and Discounts

You will often need to calculate percentages in real-world scenarios, such as finding a discount.

To find a percentage of a number, convert the percentage to a decimal and multiply.

- **Example:** A kindergarten teacher is buying sensory bins that cost \$300. There is a 20% discount. What is the final price?
 - Step 1: Convert 20% to 0.20.
 - Step 2: Multiply $300 \times 0.20 = 60$ (The discount is \$60).
 - Step 3: Subtract the discount from the original price: $300 - 60 = 240$.

4. Basic Algebra

Algebra involves isolating a variable (usually x) on one side of the equal sign to find its value. You do this by performing the opposite operation on both sides of the equation.

- **Example:** $3x - 5 = 16$
 - Step 1 (Add 5 to both sides): $3x = 21$
 - Step 2 (Divide both sides by 3): $x = 7$

5. Geometry (Area and Perimeter)

- **Area:** The amount of space *inside* a flat, 2D shape. For a rectangle, the formula is **Length** $\times$ **Width**.
 - **Example:** A classroom rug is 12 ft long and 9 ft wide. Area = $12 \times 9 = 108$ square feet.
- **Perimeter:** The total distance *around the outside* of a shape. You find this by adding all the sides together.
 - **Example:** A rectangular K-3 play area is 40 ft long and 30 ft wide. Perimeter = $40 + 40 + 30 + 30 = 140$ feet.

6. Data and Statistics

- **Mean (Average):** Add all the numbers in a set together, then divide by the total count of numbers.
 - *Example:* A student's spelling scores are 80, 90, 85, and 95.
 - *Step 1:* $80 + 90 + 85 + 95 = 350$
 - *Step 2:* $350 \div 4 = 87.5$ (Mean score is 87.5).

Part 2: K-3 Math Instructional Scenarios (Pedagogical Skills)

In early elementary grades, math is highly conceptual and concrete. Students aren't just memorizing formulas; they are learning what numbers actually *mean*.

1. Visual Models and Manipulatives

Young children need to touch and see math before they can do it purely in their heads (abstractly).

- **Ten-Frames (K-1st Grade):** A two-by-five grid used to develop number sense. It helps students visually "bridge to ten."
 - *Scenario:* A student is struggling with $8 + 5$.
 - *Paraeducator Role:* Have the student place 8 counters in the first Ten-Frame. Then, ask them to add 5 more. They will see that 2 counters fill up the first frame (making 10), and 3 "spill over" into the next frame, making 13.
- **Base-Ten Blocks (1st-3rd Grade):** Used to teach place value (ones, tens, hundreds). A "flat" is 100, a "rod" is 10, and a "unit" is 1.
 - *Scenario:* A student doesn't understand that the "2" in 25 means twenty, not two. Base-ten blocks make this physically obvious (two rods and five units).
- **Fraction Tiles/Circles (3rd Grade):** Physical pieces that represent parts of a whole.
 - *Scenario:* A student doesn't believe that $\frac{1}{2}$ is equal to $\frac{2}{4}$. Let them physically stack two $\frac{1}{4}$ pieces on top of one $\frac{1}{2}$ piece so they can see they take up the exact same amount of space.

2. Error Analysis (Finding the "Why")

When a student gets a math problem wrong, an effective paraeducator doesn't just say, "That's wrong, try again." They look at the answer to figure out *why* the student is confused.

- **The Regrouping Error (Subtraction):**

- *Problem:* $52 - 18 = ?$
- *Student Answer:* 44
- *Analysis:* The student didn't know how to "borrow" or regroup. Instead, they just looked at the ones column (2 and 8) and subtracted the smaller number from the larger number ($8 - 2 = 6$), or they just guessed 4, completely ignoring that the 8 is on the bottom.
- **The Place Value Error (Multiplication):**
 - *Problem:* $14 \times 3 = ?$
 - *Student Answer:* 312
 - *Analysis:* The student multiplied 3×4 to get 12, and 3×1 to get 3, and just wrote the numbers side-by-side (3 and 12). They do not understand how to carry the ten into the next place value column.

3. Word Problem Strategies

Word problems are notoriously difficult for young students because they combine reading comprehension with math computation.

- **Ineffective Approach:** Saying, "Just look at the numbers and add them together," or doing the math for them to save time.
- **Effective Scaffolding:**
 1. Read the problem aloud together.
 2. Ask the student to visualize the story (e.g., "Imagine Maria holding 5 apples...").
 3. Have the student circle the important numbers and underline the actual question being asked.
 4. Ask guiding questions: "Are we getting more apples, or taking apples away? What math symbol means 'getting more'?"

4. Addressing Math Anxiety

Many students develop math anxiety very early. When faced with a full worksheet, a student might cross their arms, shut down, or cry.

- **The "Chunking" Strategy:** The brain gets overwhelmed by too much visual input. Take a blank piece of paper and cover up the entire worksheet except for the very first step of the very first problem. Say, "We are only going to look at this one little piece right now."

5. Checking for Understanding

- **The "Nodding" Trap:** If you explain a concept and ask, "Does that make sense?", 90% of young students will nod "yes" even if they are completely lost, because they want to please you or avoid looking foolish.

- **The Pedagogical Solution:** To truly check for understanding, say: "Okay, now it's your turn. I want you to do the next problem, and I want you to talk out loud and teach me how you are doing it step-by-step."

Practice Scenarios for the Assessment

1. A second-grade student is solving the problem $52 - 18$ and gets the answer 44 . What mistake is the student most likely making?

- *Correct Approach:* The student is subtracting the smaller digit from the larger digit in the ones place ($8 - 2$) instead of regrouping (borrowing from the tens place).
- *Why:* Understanding *how* a student arrived at a wrong answer allows you to target the specific skill they are missing (regrouping), rather than just reteaching basic subtraction facts.

2. A first-grade student looks at a word problem and immediately says, "I don't know what to do." What is the most effective first step a paraeducator can suggest?

- *Correct Approach:* "Let's read it together. We will circle the numbers and underline what the question is asking us to find."
- *Why:* Breaking the word problem down into actionable reading steps removes the immediate anxiety of "doing math" and helps the student isolate the necessary information.

3. You are helping a first-grade student understand how to add $8 + 5$. What is the best way to model this visually?

- *Correct Approach:* Use a Ten-Frame to show 8 counters, then add 5 more counters, showing how it fills the first frame to make 10 and leaves 3 remaining ($10 + 3 = 13$).
- *Why:* K-1 students need concrete visual models to bridge to ten, rather than just being told to memorize a math fact or count on their fingers.

4. After explaining a new math concept to a second-grade student, what is the most reliable way to ensure they actually understand it before moving on?

- *Correct Approach:* Ask the student to talk you through their steps out loud as they solve the next problem on their own.
- *Why:* Asking "Does that make sense?" only elicits a yes/no response. Having the student teach it back to you forces them to demonstrate true comprehension.

Key Takeaway for the Exam: In K-3 math scenarios, look for answers that involve **using visual models (manipulatives), breaking tasks down into smaller steps, asking the student to explain their thinking, and analyzing the root cause of an error.**

Sample Assessment

Title I Paraprofessional

Sample Assessment

Instructions: This sample assessment is designed to help you practice for the Title I Paraprofessional Exam. It includes 15 questions covering Reading, Writing, and Math. Each section tests both your foundational knowledge (Personal Proficiency) and your ability to assist K-3 students (Instructional Capability).

Choose the best answer for each question. An answer key with explanations is provided at the end.

Section 1: Reading

1. Read the following sentence: "Sam sighed, closed his heavy textbook, rubbed his eyes, and looked at the clock displaying 2:00 AM." What can you infer from this sentence?

- A) Sam is excited to go to school tomorrow.
- B) Sam is tired and has been studying for a long time.
- C) Sam is angry that his alarm clock went off early.
- D) Sam's textbook is too difficult for him to read.

2. "The teacher's instructions for the art project were *ambiguous*, leading to confusion among the kindergarteners." In this sentence, *ambiguous* means:

- A) Very clear and easy to follow.
- B) Loud and aggressive.
- C) Unclear or open to multiple interpretations.
- D) Scientifically accurate.

3. A kindergarten student is looking at a picture book and stops at the word "bat." They look frustrated and say, "I can't read this." What is the best response?

- A) Read the word "bat" for them so they do not lose confidence.
- B) Ask, "What sound does the first letter make? Let's stretch out the sounds."
- C) Tell them to look at the picture and just guess whatever animal is there.
- D) Tell them to skip the page and keep reading.

4. You are doing a reading intervention with a second-grade student who reads the words accurately but in a slow, robotic, monotone voice. What is the best strategy to use?

- A) Have the student write down all the vocabulary words.
- B) Have the student read silently for 20 minutes.
- C) Tell the student to read faster.
- D) Use Echo Reading, where you read a sentence with proper expression, and the student repeats it back using the same tone.

5. A third-grade student finishes reading a page about the water cycle and says, "I have no idea what I just read." What should you do?

- A) Tell the student to reread the page slowly and stop after every paragraph to verbally summarize what just happened.
- B) Tell the student to just keep reading, and it will make sense eventually.
- C) Tell the student to look up the word "water" in the glossary.
- D) Read the page aloud to the student while they close their eyes.

Section 2: Writing

6. Choose the sentence with the correct subject-verb agreement:

- A) The box of crayons belong on the teacher's desk.
- B) Every one of the students are getting a sticker today.
- C) The class has decided to play a game before lunch.
- D) Neither the teacher nor the students is ready for recess.

7. Identify the sentence that is a fragment (not a complete thought):

- A) The children played outside.
- B) Waiting for the school bus in the pouring rain.
- C) The bell rang, so they packed their bags.
- D) He laughed.

8. A second-grade student is staring at a blank piece of paper for a writing prompt titled "My Favorite Animal." The student says, "I don't know what to write." What is the best

instructional prompt?

- A) "Just write about a dog; that is an easy animal to write about."
- B) "Let's brainstorm. Do you have any pets at home, or what animal do you like seeing at the zoo?"
- C) "You have to write something right now, or you will lose recess time."
- D) "Look up the word 'animal' in the dictionary and copy the definition."

9. A first-grade student is writing a story but stops after every word to ask you how to spell it. How should the paraeducator respond to promote writing fluency?

- A) Spell every single word for them so the rough draft is perfectly accurate.
- B) Make them look up every unknown word in a dictionary.
- C) Take the pencil and write the story for them as they dictate it.
- D) Tell them to write the sounds they hear (inventive spelling) and circle words they aren't sure about to fix later during editing.

10. You are helping a third-grade student with the *Revising* stage of their short story. Which of the following should you focus on?

- A) Asking the student if their story has a clear beginning, middle, and end, and if the events make sense.
- B) Checking that all names and places are capitalized.
- C) Ensuring every sentence ends with a period or question mark.
- D) Correcting all the misspelled words with a red pen.

Section 3: Math

11. Simplify the following expression: $8 + 4 \times 3 - 2$

- A) 34
- B) 18
- C) 14
- D) 22

12. A teacher wants to put a new rug in her classroom. The rectangular space for the rug is 12 ft long and 9 ft wide. What is the area of the space?

- A) 42 square feet
- B) 21 square feet
- C) 108 square feet
- D) 81 square feet

13. A second-grade student is solving the problem $52 - 18$ and gets the answer 44. What mistake is the student most likely making?

- A) The student is adding the numbers instead of subtracting.
- B) The student is subtracting the smaller digit from the larger digit in the ones place ($8 - 2$) instead of regrouping (borrowing from the tens place).
- C) The student forgot to write the negative sign.
- D) The student does not know their basic addition facts.

14. You are helping a first-grade student understand how to add $8 + 5$. What is the best way to model this visually?

- A) Tell them to memorize it because it is a basic math fact.
- B) Explain that they should just write 13 and move on to the next problem.
- C) Use a Ten-Frame to show 8 counters, then add 5 more counters, showing how it fills the first frame to make 10 and leaves 3 remaining.
- D) Ask them, "Does that make sense?" and wait for them to nod.

15. A student looks at a math worksheet filled with word problems, crosses their arms, and says, "I can't do this, it's too much." What is the most appropriate pedagogical response?

- A) "That's okay, not everyone is a math person. Just do your best."
- B) "Let's cover up the rest of the page with a blank paper and just read the very first sentence

of problem number one together."

C) "If you don't finish this, you will have to stay in during recess."

D) "I'll do the first five for you so you have less to do."

Answer Key & Explanations

1. Answer: B.

Explanation: The text does not explicitly say Sam is tired, but we can *infer* it based on clues: sighing, rubbing eyes, heavy textbook, and the late hour (2:00 AM).

2. Answer: C.

Explanation: Context clues. If the instructions led to "confusion," we can deduce that the instructions were unclear or ambiguous.

3. Answer: B.

Explanation: Giving the child the answer (A) or letting them guess randomly (C) does not teach them how to read. Prompting them to use their phonics skills (sounding it out) builds independent reading skills.

4. Answer: D.

Explanation: The student lacks *prosody* (expression). Echo reading allows the paraeducator to model what fluent, expressive reading sounds like so the student can mimic it.

5. Answer: A.

Explanation: Summarizing and chunking text are active comprehension strategies. If they don't understand it, just reading further won't help.

6. Answer: C.

Explanation: "Class" is a collective noun acting as a single unit, so it takes the singular verb "has." (A is incorrect because the subject is "box", which is singular and needs "belongs". B is incorrect because "Every one" is singular and needs "is").

7. Answer: B.

Explanation: "Waiting for the school bus in the pouring rain" is missing a subject. We don't know *who* is waiting.

8. Answer: B.

Explanation: The pre-writing stage should involve scaffolding through brainstorming and

making personal connections. Telling them what to write (A) stunts their creative process.

9. Answer: D.

Explanation: For early drafts, the goal is *fluency* (getting ideas on paper). Stopping to spell every word perfectly interrupts their train of thought. Using "inventive spelling" allows them to keep writing.

10. Answer: A.

Explanation: *Revising* is about the content, organization, and flow of the story. Checking capitalization, punctuation, and spelling (options B, C, and D) is *editing*.

11. Answer: B.

Explanation: Follow PEMDAS. Multiplication first ($4 \times 3 = 12$). Then rewrite: $8 + 12 - 2$.
Addition/Subtraction from left to right: $20 - 2 = 18$.

12. Answer: C.

Explanation: Area = Length $\times$ Width. $12 \times 9 = 108$.

13. Answer: B.

Explanation: This is a classic regrouping error. The student didn't know how to borrow from the 5, so they just subtracted the 2 from the 8. Understanding *why* they got it wrong helps you fix the actual gap in their knowledge.

14. Answer: C.

Explanation: K-1 students need concrete visual models to understand how numbers work. The Ten-Frame helps them visually "bridge to ten" ($8 + 2 = 10$, with 3 leftover equals 13) rather than just rote memorization.

15. Answer: B.

Explanation: The student is experiencing math anxiety from being visually overwhelmed. "Chunking" (covering up the rest of the page) reduces visual input and makes the task manageable. Doing the work for them (D) doesn't teach them, and threatening them (C) increases anxiety.